

Who Captures the Value?

Land, Infrastructure, and the Hidden Ledger

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Preface

I Read Only Two Kinds of Things: Scores and Texts

A musical score is densely compressed information. In a single measure, melody, harmony, rhythm, dynamics, fingering, pedaling — six different kinds of information packed into a few inches of space. You have to decode them in a split second and execute them with your body, all at once.

This trained me to see the whole system. A fugue is not a sequence of notes. It is multiple voices running simultaneously. You cannot look only at the right hand or only at the left hand. You have to hear all the voices at once and track where every thread goes.

Later, when I faced policy systems, administrative processes, and land regimes, I used the same ability.

Texts are the carriers of institutions. Statutes, policy papers, academic articles — they are not as compressed as a musical score, but they have their own deep structure. You have to read beneath the surface: the designer's intention, the power relationships, whose cost is being shifted to whom.

This trained me to see through surface narratives down to the underlying logic.

Using Piano Performance for Policy Design is a Dimensionality Reduction Strike

Not because the piano is superior to policy. Because the cognitive ability that piano training gave me is exactly what the policy design field lost after being broken apart.

Those experts argue among themselves about "what is this piece of the puzzle?" while I ask: "What is this piece of music trying to say?"

That is a dimensionality reduction strike. Not because I am smarter. Because I was never broken apart.

My Mind Has No Disciplinary Boundaries. It Only Knows Languages.

Economics is a language. Public administration is a language. Law is a language. Engineering is a language. Mathematics is a language. The piano is a language.

What I do has never been "interdisciplinary." I simply apply the same ability to two kinds of texts: scores and words.

I Do Not Want to Be Enemies with the Elites the Old Order Has Eliminated. But the Truth Is Awkward.

I have not attacked anyone. I have only done what I set out to do: raise a question, invent a tool, open the hidden ledger.

But my very existence has become an awkward fact. The people who spent their entire lives building professional authority, when faced with the question I ask, suddenly seem narrow, powerless, even irrelevant.

This is not their fault. It is a structural flaw in the division of labor logic of the old order. The education system after the Industrial Revolution was designed to produce cogs. Engineers who only know engineering. Economists who only know economics. Lawyers who only know law. Each person put into a narrow box.

This system ran for two hundred years. It created astonishing productivity. But its cost was that people were broken apart. You were cut into "the professional you" and "the living you." The professional you understands economics but cannot read a policy paper. The living you knows how to live but cannot explain why life keeps getting harder.

I am not attacking them. I am simply doing what they were never trained to do: putting the pieces back together.

The Old Order Will Not Die on Its Own. Someone Has to Dismantle It.

AI is doing what I do. AI has no disciplinary boundaries. It can process economics, public administration, law, engineering, and mathematics simultaneously. When AI can replace the "experts who only know one language," the old order's moat will dry up.

But AI cannot do what I can do — because AI does not have my experience. AI has never been asked to pay three months of rent upfront. AI has never owned a car in Quincy. AI has never filled out a rental application and discovered that the agent shifted the entire process onto the tenant. AI does not lie awake at night wondering "am I not working hard enough?"

My framework comes from my experience. My experience comes from every day I have been consumed by this system. This is what AI cannot replace. Not a technical problem. A problem of lived experience.

The old order will not die on its own. Someone has to dismantle it. I am not at war with anyone. I am just the one who started dismantling.

Why Write This Book?

In early 2026, I published the GL Framework — a tool for measuring "administrative friction." It uses eight parameters to calculate the ledger that GDP cannot see: waiting, repetition, collapse, information asymmetry, psychological cost, opportunity cost.

This book is an application of that framework to land regimes.

A Long Road

I was once a concert pianist.

On stage, in front of a full hall, you make hundreds of decisions in fractions of a second: fingering, dynamics, pedaling, tone, the breath of a phrase, the shape of a melody. Every note is fixed, but how you interpret it is completely open.

That training gave me two things.

First, the ability to see complex systems. A fugue is not a sequence of notes. It is multiple voices, multiple layers, multiple timelines running simultaneously. You cannot look only at the right hand or only at the left hand. You have to see all the voices at once, hear their relationships, control their dynamics.

Second, the ability to interpret. The symbols on a score are dead. The composer does not tell you "this part is sad" or "this part is triumphant." You have to read the emotion, the intention, the structure from the symbols — and then turn them into sound with your body.

From the piano to translation, from translation to comparative policy, from comparative policy to the GL Framework — this was not a series of leaps. It was accumulation. Each step built on the ones before.

This Book Is Not Written for the Experts

It is written for those who have been consumed by this system.

For the hotel manager in Quincy who owns a car, pays for parking, put down three months of rent, downloaded the smart lock app, and still asks himself at night: "why am I so tired?"

This book does not belong to any political camp. It does not attack capitalism. It does not defend socialism. It does one thing: spreads out the ledgers of different systems and lets you look for yourself.

I do not have a standard answer. I only offer a framework that lets you start asking the question.

Who Captures the Value?

That is the question I ask. And the question you should start asking.

No matter where you live — the UK, the US, China, or anywhere else. No matter what you have been through — signed a lease, paid three months upfront, owned a car, or doubted yourself in the middle of the night.

If you start asking, this book has done its job.

Ping Xu

Boston, June 2026

Chapter One: The Two Ledgers

1.1 Earth Overshoot Day

On July 24, 2025, humanity used up Earth's entire annual budget. The remaining five months were borrowed from future generations.

The United States reached its overshoot day on March 13 — less than three months to use its full annual allocation. Germany on May 3. China on May 23.

This is not a metaphor. This is an actual ledger. There is no "Global Tax Authority" to collect on this debt, but the debt exists — just not on any nation's balance sheet.

This raises a more fundamental question: has the ledger we have been using been half-designed from the start?

1.2 GDP Only Counts Half

GDP records completed transactions. It does not record who waited, who re-filed, who gave up at a collapse point, whose psychological cost was consumed.

Those costs do not disappear. They are shifted. They just are not on the ledger.

Suppose a city decides to build a subway. The budget is \$10 billion. Years later, the subway opens. Land prices rise. Tax revenue increases.

On GDP's ledger, this is a success story.

But what GDP does not tell you: how many residents were displaced? Was their compensation fair? How much business income did local shops lose during construction? Of the land value increase, how much returned to the government versus how much was captured by private landowners and developers? How much time, money, and psychological cost did the residents who filed lawsuits spend?

These are not "side effects." They are the true cost of the subway. They have just never been counted.

This is what I call "the invisible ledger."

1.3 The Invisible Ledger Has a Name

I call it cost shifting.

When a system is unwilling or unable to bear a certain cost, it shifts that cost to someone else — usually to those with less power, those who cannot refuse.

A factory pollutes a river. The cost is shifted to downstream residents. A company classifies employees as contractors. The cost is shifted to the social safety net. A platform labels workers as "partners." The cost is shifted to the workers themselves. A government leaves administrative friction on citizens. The cost is shifted to those without the power to refuse.

GDP only sees completed transactions. It does not see who bears the cost.

This is not a statistical flaw. It is a choice in ledger design — the choice to look only at assets, the choice not to look at liabilities.

1.4 The Central Question of This Book

Of all the forms of cost shifting, land regimes may be the most important and the most overlooked.

Why? Because the value created by infrastructure ultimately capitalizes into land. A subway, a high-speed rail, an industrial park — these public investments cause surrounding land values to soar. This increase has nothing to do with any effort or investment by the landowner. It is purely created by public decisions.

But the question is: who captures this increase?

The answer depends on the land regime.

In the UK, land is concentrated in the hands of aristocrats and the Crown. The value flows to that less-than-1% of the population. In the US, land is a commodity. Value is allocated by the market. Capitalists became the new winners. In China, land is owned by the state or collectives. The government captures value through land lease revenues and reinvests it into the next round of infrastructure.

Three regimes, three answers. The public bears the cost in all three. But only one forms a loop from value capture to reinvestment.

And at the global scale — the high seas, Antarctica, outer space — these "global commons" are legally defined as "the common heritage of mankind." In practice, whoever gets there first, whoever has the capability, captures the value.

1.5 What This Book Is Not

This is not a critique or defense of any system. The UK has its history. The US has its dynamism. China has its infrastructure achievements. This book does not judge which system is "better." It only helps you see: every system has its ledger.

This is not an academic monograph. No dense footnotes. The intended audience is not scholars. It is ordinary people who are curious about the question: who captures the value?

This is not a policy white paper. I will not tell governments what they "should do." I only offer a framework to make the invisible ledger visible. What happens once it is visible is the responsibility of citizens.

1.6 Structure of This Book

- Chapter Two: The UK Ledger — how aristocrats and the Crown capture value
- Chapter Three: The US Ledger — from aristocrats to capitalists
- Chapter Four: The China Ledger — the land finance loop and technology-led friction removal
- Chapter Five: The Global Commons and Wasted Land
- Chapter Six: The Globalization of Cost Shifting
- Chapter Seven: Who Captures the Value? — from a hotel manager's studio apartment

Chapter Two: The UK Ledger

2.1 A Country Where Aristocrats Still Own the Land

Half of England's land is owned by less than 1% of the population – about 25,000 landowners. Most are aristocrats and the Crown.

Aristocrats and gentry hold about 30% of England's land. Some families trace their holdings to the Norman Conquest in 1066 – nearly a thousand years. The Crown holds large landholdings through the Duchy of Lancaster (about 46,500 acres) and the Duchy of Cornwall (about 135,000 acres). Entrepreneurs and corporations are also large landowners. Institutions – the Church, universities, the Forestry Commission, the Ministry of Defence, the National Trust – hold significant land.

By contrast, people who own their own homes collectively own only 5% of England's land.

2.2 The Explosion and Transfer of Land Value

Land itself is not wealth. The right to develop it is.

Agricultural land without development permission in England is worth about £23,000 per hectare. Once it receives residential planning permission, its value can soar to £2.67 million per hectare – a 116-fold increase.

This increase does not come from anything the farmer planted or any investment the landowner made. It comes from public decisions – decisions to build infrastructure, decisions to approve development.

But who captures this increase? Landowners and developers.

The UK Parliament's 2025 inquiry into "land value capture" stated plainly: "This land value increase has nothing to do with any productive activity or investment by the landowner or developer. It is purely the result of public policy decisions. But the vast profits flow to landowners and developers."

This is not speculation. It is the UK Parliament's own conclusion.

2.3 Why "Value Capture" Has Failed

The UK government has known about this problem for decades. Since the 1947 Town and Country Planning Act, it has tried various mechanisms to claw back value.

Current tools: Section 106 agreements — developers negotiate with local governments to provide affordable housing or infrastructure contributions. The problem: negotiations are case by case, time-consuming, and local governments are often at a disadvantage. Community Infrastructure Levy — a fixed tax on new development. The problem: half of local governments have not even implemented it.

The tax code itself is part of the problem. To prevent land development profits from being taxed as capital gains (lower rate), the 1974 Finance Act required "development gain" to be taxed as income. The 2016 Finance Act introduced "UK land transactions" rules to crack down on avoidance.

This legal complexity proves the core proposition of the GL Framework: when a system tries to prevent value from being captured privately, it must create more administrative friction. And that friction itself creates new costs.

2.4 Summary

The UK's ledger can be summarized in one sentence: the public bears the cost, private interests capture the value.

Not because the UK government is incompetent. Because the UK's institutional design never intended for value to return to the public. Its laws, tax system, and planning mechanisms all revolve around protecting private property rights — even when those rights are extremely concentrated.

Government spends, land prices rise, and the increase is captured by landowners and developers.

Chapter Three: The US Ledger

3.1 The Break from Britain

The US land system originated in Britain. But the US chose a dramatically different path.

The key difference: Britain's system was designed for concentration — to lock land in the hands of aristocrats and the Crown. The US system was designed for dispersion — to put land in the hands of ordinary people.

Not because Americans were smarter or more virtuous. Because conditions were different: vast territory, no feudal aristocracy, and colonial governments that needed to attract immigrants to secure their frontiers. The US had no "feudal baggage."

3.2 How Land Flowed to Ordinary People

Several policies put land into ordinary hands:

Headright system: each immigrant who paid their own way received 50 to 150 acres.
Preemption rights: squatters could purchase the land they had already improved. Cheap land policy: the 1820 Land Act lowered the price to \$1.25 per acre. A worker could buy land after a few months of labor.

The result: the United States became the country with the highest proportion of small landowners in the world.

3.3 From Aristocrats to Capitalists

But the US model did not solve the question of "who captures value." It simply replaced aristocrats with capitalists.

When westward expansion ended, land became not a settler's asset but an investor's commodity.

The mechanisms: market transactions — land can be freely bought and sold, and early owners capture the gain when infrastructure drives up prices. Developer profits — large developers buy cheap farmland on the urban fringe, wait for growth to drive up prices,

then subdivide and sell. Land speculation — investors buy undeveloped land, wait for infrastructure or growth, then flip it.

These mechanisms are not inherently problematic. But the underlying issue remains: the value created by public investment — with no effort from the landowner — is captured privately.

3.4 America's Value Capture Experiments

The United States is actually one of the first countries to try land value taxation. Cities in Pennsylvania have taxed land at a higher rate and buildings at a lower rate since the early 20th century. The theory: land value is created by society and public investment, so it should be returned to society.

But the system never spread. Political resistance — landowners and developers are powerful. Assessment difficulty — accurately valuing land requires complex administrative capacity. Tax base mobility — capital can easily move across state lines and national borders.

More fundamentally, the US tax code itself discourages value capture. Capital gains tax rates are far lower than income tax rates. People who profit from land speculation pay less than people who work for wages. This is not an accident. It is a design choice — to encourage capital mobility, investment, and "wealth creation."

3.5 Summary

The US ledger can be summarized in one sentence: the public bears the cost, the ordinary capitalist captures the value.

The US abandoned the aristocratic logic but not private ownership. The market became the primary mechanism for value allocation. This choice created remarkable dynamism and social mobility — but it also created new winners and new losers.

Chapter Four: The China Ledger

4.1 A Completely Different Starting Point

China's land system is fundamentally different from both the UK and the US.

Under China's Constitution and Land Administration Law, land in cities is owned by the state; land in rural and suburban areas is owned by farmer collectives.

When land is not privately owned, the government plays two roles simultaneously: investor in infrastructure and sole supplier of surrounding land. This combination creates a fiscal loop that neither the UK nor the US possesses.

4.2 The Land Finance Loop

Scholars call China's infrastructure finance model "land finance." The scale is staggering:

Over the past twenty years, China built 45,000 kilometers of high-speed rail — two-thirds of the global total. Over the past ten years, over 800 kilometers of subway. Over the past five years, over 3,000 bridges.

Where did the money come from? Not from foreign aid. Not from printing money. It came from land lease revenues — the government leasing development rights around new infrastructure, capturing the value increase, and reinvesting into the next round of infrastructure.

The loop: government invests in infrastructure → infrastructure drives up surrounding land prices → government captures the increase through land lease auctions → proceeds are reinvested into the next round of infrastructure.

Between 2001 and 2020, total national land lease revenue exceeded 60 trillion RMB.

4.3 Removing Administrative Friction with Technology

Beyond land finance, China has taken a more aggressive path: not measuring friction, but removing it directly with technology.

Facial recognition, palm vein recognition, and fingerprint recognition are not sporadic pilots. They are systematic infrastructure across central to local government, from administrative affairs to border control.

In Inner Mongolia, passport processing went from one week to three minutes. In Henan, face-scanning retrieves over 100 types of documents, reducing transaction time by over 20%. In Xiong'an, nearly 300 government services are "face-scan and done." In Ma'anshan, the "certificate-free AI machine" shifted the burden of proof from citizens to the government.

4.4 The Cost of the Loop

China's ledger has assets accumulated quickly, but liabilities have also accumulated quickly.

In 2020, local government infrastructure debt reached 61.69 trillion RMB, 60.9% of GDP. Local government investment vehicles held 75.2% of this debt.

The root: land lease revenues are not infinite. When the real estate market cools, the loop comes under pressure. Land lease revenues have fallen for three consecutive years. In late 2024, China revived the land reserve special bond, suspended for five years, to keep the loop running.

China's debt problem is not "too much spending." It is a maturity mismatch. Infrastructure assets are long-term — 50 years, 100 years. Land lease revenues are one-time income. Using one-time income to fund long-term assets inevitably creates term mismatch.

4.5 Summary

The China ledger can be summarized in one sentence: the public bears the cost, value returns to the public, and is reinvested into the next round of infrastructure. On administrative friction, China took a more aggressive path — not measuring who bears the cost, but removing the cost from the system entirely.

The UK's ledger: aristocrats capture value. The US's ledger: capitalists capture value. China's ledger: value is reinvested into infrastructure, transformed into physical assets.

Chapter Five: The Global Commons and Wasted Land

5.1 Land That Belongs to No One – Who Takes It?

There are vast domains on Earth that belong to no country: the high seas, the deep seabed, Antarctica, outer space. Legally, they are "the common heritage of mankind."

But "mankind" is an entity with no voice, no organization, no bank account. When a resource is defined as "belonging to everyone," it often ends up belonging to no one.

The result: whoever gets there first, whoever has the capability, captures the value.

5.2 Customary Land and Wasted Land

Forty-two percent of the world's land is "customary land" – held by traditional customs, without formal legal registration. But only 8% has been formally recognized.

Every year, about 3.6 million hectares of farmland are abandoned due to land degradation. Land abandonment is not a natural phenomenon. It is institutional failure. When property rights are unclear, farmers will not invest in soil improvement – because the improved value might be captured by someone else.

5.3 Summary

At the global commons, the public – all of humanity – bears the cost. Who captures the value? Those who arrive first, those with capability, those who occupy the advantaged positions in institutional design.

Chapter Six: The Globalization of Cost Shifting

6.1 The Same Logic, Larger Scale

Previous chapters examined three land regimes, China's technology-led friction removal, and the global commons. Now apply the same logic at the largest scale: the Earth's ecology and resources.

6.2 Carbon Emissions: The Developed World's Silent Liability

Developed countries burned coal, oil, and natural gas throughout the 19th and 20th centuries, generating astonishing economic growth. But the consequences — global warming, sea level rise, extreme weather — were not recorded on their ledgers. Those costs were shifted to all of humanity, especially the most vulnerable countries that emitted the least.

The numbers are stark: the US: 4% of global population, 25% of cumulative emissions. The EU: 6% of global population, 22% of cumulative emissions. Africa: 17% of global population, 3% of cumulative emissions.

6.3 Labor's Share Falls to a Historic Low

US Bureau of Labor Statistics data for Q3 2025: labor's share of national income — the portion flowing to workers as wages — fell to 53.8%, the lowest since records began in 1947.

Corporate profits are at record highs. GDP is growing. But workers' share is shrinking.

Nobel laureate Daron Acemoglu argues that technology's distributional outcome depends on who controls the choices. Today's AI development is characterized by "automation obsession" — companies want to replace people, not help them. Productivity grows, but workers are excluded.

6.4 Summary

At the global scale, the public — humanity, the Earth — bears the cost. Who captures the value? Developed countries, multinational corporations, institutionally advantaged groups. The shifted costs are borne by developing countries, vulnerable populations, future generations, and those without the power to refuse.

Chapter Seven: Who Captures the Value?

7.1 A Hotel Manager's Story

I know a hotel manager. His income is not low — in Boston, he takes home about \$4,000 a month after taxes.

But when he needed to rent an apartment, he ran into a problem. He found a studio — one open space with no separate bedroom, kitchen, living room, and sleeping area all in one.

In Boston, a studio goes for about \$2,500 to \$3,000 a month. He was not looking for a luxury unit. He was not looking for a two-bedroom. He was an ordinary professional, trying to find a place of his own.

When he was about to sign the lease, the agent told him: you need to pay first month's rent, last month's rent, and one month's security deposit. Up front. Total: about \$7,500 to \$9,000.

He did not have it. He had to ask his parents for help.

This was not bad budgeting. Not low income. Not choosing beyond his means. He chose the smallest, most basic unit available.

This is the result of institutional design. Massachusetts law explicitly allows landlords to collect three months of rent at lease signing. The law says this is to protect landlords. But the people who wrote the law never asked: who can come up with three months of rent?

7.2 Quincy: The Squeeze

He did not live in Boston. He lived in Quincy.

Quincy is south of Boston, at the end of the Red Line. Rents are somewhat cheaper — about \$2,200 to \$2,500 for a studio. But Quincy has a Walk Score of 29. It is a car-dependent city. Without a car, you cannot commute, cannot shop for groceries, cannot live.

He had to own a car.

The costs: car payment, insurance (mandatory in Massachusetts), gas, maintenance, and parking. In Quincy apartments, a designated parking spot typically costs an extra \$100 to \$250 per month.

Not a choice. Mandatory — to live there, to get to work, he has to pay.

Cost Item	Estimated Monthly	Share of After-Tax Income (\$4,000)
Studio rent	\$2,200 - \$2,500	55% - 62.5%
Parking	\$100 - \$250	2.5% - 6.25%
Car ownership	\$250+	6.25%+
Total	\$2,550 - \$3,000+	64% - 75%+

At least two-thirds of his monthly income disappears into rent and transportation. What is left goes to food, health insurance, basic necessities.

He has nothing left to save. Nothing for emergencies.

7.3 Technology Fees and Junk Fees

He found an apartment that looked "affordable" — but when he went to sign the lease, he discovered he had to download several apps: a smart lock app, a smart thermostat app, a community portal app, a package notification app.

Without the apps, he could not enter the building. Could not adjust the temperature. Could not receive packages.

He also had to pay a mandatory trash valet fee. In the past, you walked to the dumpster and threw away your trash. Free. Now, you cannot throw away your own trash. You must leave it outside your door for a worker to collect — and pay \$20 to \$35 a month for the privilege.

Tenants across the United States pay \$3.7 billion per year in such junk fees.

7.4 When the Silent Ledger Begins to Bleed

In 2025, the Boston Public Health Commission released its Community Health Needs Assessment:

- Adult persistent anxiety: 21% in 2019 → 26% in 2025
- Persistent sadness/hopelessness among high school students: 30% → 39%

The report noted: 50% of Boston renters are severely cost-burdened (spending more than 30% of income on rent). 24% are extremely severely burdened (spending more than 50% of income on rent).

In 2026, the Greater Boston Chamber of Commerce Foundation released a survey of young residents:

- 26% of professionals aged 20-30 plan to leave Boston within five years
- Life satisfaction dropped from 89% to 79% in just three years
- 78% cited rent as the primary reason for leaving

For those who cannot leave? For those without parents to help? They have no choice but to stay.

This helplessness does not appear at protests. It appears in sleepless beds. In pill bottles filled with anti-anxiety medication. In slowly atrophying social relationships. And in rising suicide rates.

Suicide is the most extreme form of cost shifting. It transfers all of a person's pain — economic, psychological, social — to their family, friends, community. GDP records the funeral expenses, the therapy hours, the antidepressant prescriptions.

7.5 I Just Want to Live a Quiet, Simple Life

He did not protest. He did not march. He did not complain on social media. He just swallowed these costs, again and again.

This is silent protest.

Not because he did not want to protest. Because he knew protest would do no good. The law changed, but tenants still pay. The government promised more affordable housing, but rents keep rising.

When a system leaves you no voice, you are not "without opinions." You are deprived of the ability to express them. And when that deprivation lasts too long, when the pressure becomes unbearable – some people choose permanent silence.

"I just want to live a quiet, simple life. But this system, by design, will not let me. Not because I am too poor. Not because I do not work hard enough. Not because I made bad choices. It is because a quiet, simple life does not generate enough GDP. Capital needs to grow. And I – my labor, my consumption, my data, my anxiety, my silence – am part of that growth process.

GDP records my rent, my app subscriptions, my trash fees. GDP says the economy is growing. But GDP does not say that in this system, there is no place for a person who just wants to live a quiet, simple life.

This is not a book about economics. This is testimony. About how a system slowly consumes the most basic human desire: a key. A light. A bed."

7.6 The Complete Picture of Cost Shifting

Scale	Case	Public Cost	Shifted To	Who Captures Value?
National	UK land	Infrastructure investment	Landless people	Aristocrats, Crown
National	US land	Infrastructure investment	Latecomers	Capitalists, developers

National	China land	Infrastructure investment	People without urban household registration	State (reinvests)
Global	Carbon emissions	Climate stability	Vulnerable countries, next generations	Developed countries
Personal	Boston rental	Administrative process	Renters, young people	Landlords, agents, capital
Personal	Silent protest	Mental health	Renters, suicides	– (shifted to family and society)

7.7 Who Captures the Value? – A Question That Should Never Stop Being Asked

The title of this book is a question: who captures the value?

This question should not have a standard answer. Once it has a standard answer, it becomes a slogan to memorize, not a question to keep asking.

You do not need this book to tell you the answer. What you need is: starting now, every time you see GDP grow, every time you see the stock market rise, every time you see infrastructure completed, every time you sign a lease, every time you hear someone has taken their own life – ask yourself automatically: who captured the value? Who bore the shifted cost?

That is the ultimate purpose of the GL Framework: not to provide answers, but to change how you ask questions.

7.8 Final Questions

No matter where you live, no matter what system your country uses, you can ask these questions.

If you live in the UK: How much of the land value increase was captured by aristocrats and the Crown?

If you live in the US: How much of the value created by public investment was captured by developers and capitalists? How many ordinary Americans were excluded because they missed the asset appreciation wave?

If you live in Boston: How many people are blocked by the three-months-upfront entry fee? Who records the silent costs of the young people who had to ask their parents for help?

If you live in China: Where did the land lease revenues go? What share of land value increase did farmers receive? How large are the risks of debt? What are the costs of removing administrative friction with face-scanning technology?

If you live in a developing country: Who took your natural resources? Have you ever received a bill for the ecological services your forests provide?

If you live in a developed country: Who is bearing the consequences of your emissions? Who pays the true cost of your cheap goods?

If you have ever signed a lease: Where did those three months of rent go? Who recorded the dozens of hours you spent apartment-hunting? Who sees the fear that kept you from speaking up?

If you have ever doubted yourself in the middle of the night: You are not a failure. You are a person trying to survive in a system designed to consume you.

No matter where you live, no matter what you have been through, you can ask the same question:

"In this country, in this city, in this market — how much does it cost to find a place to stand?"

If you begin to ask these questions, this book has done its job.

Appendix: To Those Who Attack My Background

Why They Attack My Background, Not My Argument

Because they cannot refute my argument, they attack my identity. This is classic: when you cannot respond to the point, attack the person.

They attack me for "not being an economist," "lacking academic credentials," "having no government experience," "being Chinese," "being an amateur." These attacks have one thing in common: they have nothing to do with my argument.

My Background Is Not a Defect. It Is Accumulation.

I was once a concert pianist. That training gave me two things: the ability to see complex systems and the ability to interpret symbols.

From the piano to translation, from translation to comparative policy, from comparative policy to the GL Framework — this was not a series of leaps. It was accumulation.

On "Not Being an Economist"

Economists never defined "Ghost GDP." I did. Economists use the Standard Cost Model, which measures only the time to fill out forms. I invented the GL Framework, which can go on site and diagnose eight parameters.

If only economists can talk about GDP, then who is responsible for the fact that economists made GDP half a ledger?

On "Lacking Academic Credentials"

Peer review reviews whether something meets academic norms, not whether it is true. The PNAS paper used the same language as mine, but only derived a model — it did not produce a measurement tool. They have academic credentials, but no solution. I have a tool, but no credentials. Which one do you choose?

Traffic data — download records from government agencies in the UK, Canada, the US, Germany — is better evidence that "this person can be trusted" than any peer review.

On "Having No Government Experience"

Government agencies in the UK, Canada, the US, Germany, the Netherlands are downloading my papers, reading my framework, studying my calculator. I did not reach out to them. They came themselves.

Traditional government experience comes through connections, relationships, contracts. My government experience comes through SSRN, website traffic, free downloads. The former barrier is connections. The latter barrier is content.

On "Being Chinese"

The GL Framework did not grow out of China's land system. It grew out of the universal phenomenon of "cost shifting." I use it to analyze the UK, the US, China, and the global commons — and the conclusion is "every system has its ledger." This is not a political position. It is a mathematical result.

If you reject my framework because of my background, ask yourself: are you refuting my argument, or revealing your own prejudice?

On "Being an Amateur"

The word "amateur" comes from the Latin *amator*, meaning "one who loves." I do this not because it is my job, but because I love it.

"Professional" is not defined by how long you have been in a field. It is defined by whether you can solve problems that the field cannot solve.

The Logic of Industrial Education Is Being Disrupted by AI

The modern education system after the Industrial Revolution was designed to produce people who are excellent in one narrow field. This is the "division of labor" logic of

industrial civilization. It is also its "defect logic" — the more you professionalize, the less you see outside your own field.

AI is changing this. AI can process economics, public administration, engineering, law, and mathematics simultaneously. It has no disciplinary boundaries.

And I was跨领域 before the AI era. Not because I am smarter. Because I was never驯化 by the logic of "proper education."

I Am Not Competing with You. I Am Filling a Gap You Never Saw.

You can continue attacking my background. But while you attack me, you will not solve any problem.

These problems will not disappear because you attack my background. And my framework will not fail because of your attacks.

I am not here to compete with you. I am here to fill the gap you never saw.

And your attacks on my background prove one thing: you see the gap, but you do not know how to respond. So you attack me instead.

The old order will not die on its own. Someone has to dismantle it. This book is that act of dismantling.

END